

Crater Lake National Park - Visitor Guide

Destination: Crater Lake National Park, Oregon

Overview

Crater Lake National Park protects the deepest lake in the United States. Fed only by rain and snow, with no inflowing rivers or streams, the lake is considered one of the cleanest large bodies of water in the world, prized for its clarity and intense blue color. The lake rests inside a caldera formed 7,700 years ago when a 12,000-foot volcano called Mount Mazama collapsed following a major eruption. Later eruptions formed Wizard Island, a cinder cone near the southwest shore. The park was established in 1902 and covers 183,224 acres. Lake depth is 1,943 feet, and the highest point in the park is Mount Scott at 8,929 feet.

10 Ways to Enjoy Your Visit

Escape to Wizard Island by boat tour (July to mid-September); about 200 people per day can be "stranded" on the island for 3 hours to explore, swim, fish, and relax. Watch the park film, a 22-minute documentary shown on the hour at the Steel Visitor Center. Walk among wildflowers on the Castle Crest Trail in July and August. Find the Phantom Ship, an island that appears to be sailing away, from Sun Notch or Reflection Point. Visit the Sinnott Overlook at Rim Village for dramatic caldera views and geology exhibits. View the history exhibits at Crater Lake Lodge, first opened in 1915. Climb a peak - the summits of Watchman Peak, Garfield Peak, Union Peak, Crater Peak, and Mount Scott each offer different panoramic views. Touch the water via the steep Cleetwood Cove Trail, the only legal access to the lake shore. Take a narrated trolley tour departing daily from Rim Village. Savor a sunset from Watchman Peak or roadside pullouts on the Rim Drive.

Hiking Trails (Hidden Gems)

Godfrey Glen: An easy 1.1-mile loop through old-growth forest with canyon views, accessible to all-terrain wheelchair users with assistance. Plaikni Falls: A 2.0-mile easy walk through old-growth forest to a waterfall with abundant mid-summer wildflowers. Castle Crest: A short 0.5-mile loop through a lush meadow with abundant wildflowers from mid-July to mid-August. The Pinnacles: An easy walk along the rim of Pinnacle Valley with views of chimney-like volcanic spires formed from cooled ash. Cleetwood Cove: A strenuous 2.2-mile trail dropping 700 feet to the only legal swimming and fishing access on the lake. Garfield Peak: A 3.6-mile trail with panoramic views and diverse wildflowers, climbing 1,010 feet. Boundary Springs Trail: A moderate 5.0-mile round trip to the headwaters of the Rogue River, a quieter corner of the park. Fumarole Bay: A trail on Wizard Island itself (reachable only by tour boat) leading to a shallow, clear-water cove.

Rim Drive Highlights

Rim Drive is a 33-mile scenic road that circles the lake, typically open mid-July to late October, taking 2-3 hours to enjoy fully. Seven top stops: Discovery Point (where the lake was first spotted by a European-American in 1853), Watchman Overlook (best view of Wizard Island), Cloudcap Overlook (highest paved road in Oregon), Pumice Castle Overlook (orange pumice eroded into a castle shape), Reflection Point (view of the Phantom Ship), Pinnacles Overlook (fossil fumaroles, roughly 100 feet tall), and Vidae Falls (a spring-fed, roadside waterfall dropping 100 feet).

Local Tips

Boat tours require hiking down and back up the steep Cleetwood Cove Trail; wear sturdy footwear and bring a jacket since the lake can be windy and chilly even in summer. Swimming is only permitted at Cleetwood Cove and Wizard Island; the water is cold and most people swim for just a few minutes. Fishing requires no license; only artificial lures and flies are allowed, and no organic bait may be used to protect the lake's ecosystem. Cell reception is spotty throughout the park; the best chance of a signal is at overlooks along Rim Drive.

FAQ: How deep is Crater Lake and why is it so blue?

Crater Lake is 1,943 feet deep, the deepest lake in the USA. About 83% of its water comes directly from rain and snow. The lake appears blue because it is exceptionally clean and deep; most non-blue light wavelengths are absorbed, while blue light is scattered back to the eye.

FAQ: When is the best time to visit?

The park is open year-round, but the North Entrance and Rim Drive close for the season around November 1 or earlier with heavy snowfall. Full loop access on Rim Drive is typically available mid-July through late October. Winters are long, with an average of 42 feet of snow at Park Headquarters.

FAQ: Are pets allowed?

Pets on leash are allowed on the Godfrey Glen Trail, Pacific Crest Trail, Lady of the Woods Trail, and Grayback Road, as well as in picnic areas, campgrounds, and parking lots. They are not permitted on other trails, off-trail, or inside buildings such as Crater Lake Lodge.

FAQ: Where can I stay?

Crater Lake Lodge, open mid-May to mid-October, overlooks the lake at Rim Village with 71 rooms. The Cabins at Mazama Village have 40 units, open late May to late September. Mazama Campground has 214

sites for tents and RVs, open July through late September, with about 75% of sites reservable in advance.